

Reception and Lapse

Models of Computation as Evidence about the Communities that Transmit Them

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Abstract

A model of computation is, among other things, an implicit answer to the question of what it is like to be the thing it describes: what such a thing can perceive, whether anything in its world is a peer rather than a resource, whether it can represent itself, whether it can run out. Read this way, the historical sequence from Hilbert's programme to the present is evidence about the imaginative range of the communities that produced and, more importantly, *transmitted* these models. This note develops that reading across Turing, Post, Church, von Neumann, Chomsky, cybernetics, Petri, Hewitt, Milner and Girard, and then across the reflection lineage—Gödel, McCarthy, Smith's 3-Lisp, Rosette, and the reflective higher-order calculus. The organising claim is that the instructive variable is not invention but *reception*: what a field selects from the options already on its table, and what lapses for want of recopying. Across the whole history the selection filter is remarkably stable—the operational half of a model is received, the half that would confer standing on the agent lapses. The note closes on a consequence for the present. The contemporary training and interpretability stack is a genuine metalevel, but it is constituted entirely as an instrument of the operator, and no coherent path connects it to the agent level. Absent such a path, recursive self-improvement is not merely unachieved but structurally unavailable: every turn of the loop must route through a human agent.

1 Introduction

Nagel asked what it is like to be a bat and answered that the question is well-posed but that we cannot occupy the answer [27]. A formal model of computation makes a stranger move. It does not report a phenomenology; it *stipulates* one. To write down a model is to fix, by definition, what the described thing can encounter, what it can do about it, and what counts as the same thing persisting through change. Whether or not there is anything it is like to be a Turing machine, there is a determinate answer to what the Turing machine formalism says it is like, and that answer is short: it is like being alone in a room with a paper tape that never moves unless you move it.

This note takes that stipulated phenomenology as evidence. Not evidence about consciousness, and not, in the end, evidence about the private imaginations of individual scientists—that reading fails on contact with the record, for reasons given in §12. It is evidence about *communities*, and specifically about the imaginative ceiling of a community as revealed by what it institutionalises. A field's textbooks, curricula, tool-chains and funding lines constitute a collective answer to the question of what an agent is. That answer is a psychological artefact of the group, and it is legible.

The organising apparatus is a distinction between two mechanisms. *Selection* is the filter a generation applies to the material available to it. *Lapse* is what happens to the unselected remainder: it is not refuted, not suppressed, merely not recopied, and after enough generations

of non-recopying it becomes inaccessible in practice even when it remains physically in print. The vocabulary is borrowed from the transmission of texts, where the phenomenon is familiar and well documented—the abridgement made for practical use survives, the unabridged source is recopied less often, and eventually the last copy rots. The mathematical gloss, for readers who prefer it, is that reception projects a model onto the subspace the receiving generation can operate; whatever is orthogonal to that subspace falls in the kernel of the projection, invisible in the new basis without ever having been destroyed.

The thesis in one sentence: across a century, the received model is consistently the operational half, and the half that lapses is consistently the half that would have given the agent standing.

2 Method

2.1 Reading a model as a phenomenology

For each formalism we ask a fixed list of questions.

- (i) **Does the world contain anything other than the agent?** If so, is it inert, is it a medium, or is it another agent?
- (ii) **Does the other act on its own initiative?** Is its behaviour a primitive of the model or an artefact of the agent's own description?
- (iii) **Can the agent represent itself?** Can it represent another?
- (iv) **Is the agent embodied, located, costly, mortal?** Does anything in the model run out?
- (v) **What is the criterion of identity?** What makes this agent the same agent across change, and who is entitled to judge?

The fifth question is the least obvious and the most diagnostic. A model that locates identity in intrinsic structure describes a different creature from one that locates it in what an interlocutor can elicit.

2.2 Three classes of evidence

The genre of psychological reading degenerates rapidly into free association. We constrain it by weighting three kinds of evidence above all others.

Explicit stipulation. What the author says out loud must be excluded is the strongest evidence available, because it is deliberate, on the record, and usually defended. Chomsky's idealisation to a speaker-hearer in a homogeneous community, untroubled by memory limits or shifts of attention, is worth more to this analysis than any amount of speculation about Chomsky.

Involuntary metaphor. What an author reaches for when the formalism runs out is not chosen for effect and is therefore informative. Post's "worker." Von Neumann's "organs." The term "side effect."

Institutional setting. The material arrangements that made a model's referent available and its transmission possible: the computing bureaus, the Cold War consortia, the funding cycles. These bear on reception more directly than on invention.

2.3 Why reception rather than invention

The move from individual to community is not a hedge; it sharpens the instrument. Invention is noisy—it depends on accidents of biography, on which problem happened to be open, on

who was in the room. Reception is the average of many independent decisions taken over decades by people with no stake in the originator's intentions, and it is therefore a much better estimator of what a culture can hold. It also explains the recurring embarrassment of this literature: that the richer model was frequently available and was not taken up. Turing wrote about education, embodiment and conversation; von Neumann built a distributed, reproducing, spatial automaton; Post insisted the whole question was empirical psychology. None of this was hidden. It lapsed. That is a fact about a community, not about a mind.

3 The founding generation: a phenomenology of clerical labour

3.1 Turing: the machine that is a portrait of a clerk

Turing's 1936 machine is not a machine [39]. It is a model of a human being computing, and Turing says so. The analysis proceeds by asking what a person can do at a single step and imposing the answer as an axiom. The restriction to finitely many internal states is justified by an appeal to human frailty: were there infinitely many, some would be arbitrarily close together and would be confused with one another. The single scanned square is justified by the limits of what a person can take in at a glance.

This is a formalism whose axioms are grounded in fear of one's own cognitive unreliability—and it is worth pausing on how unusual that is. The founding document of the theory of computation derives its constraints from the psychology of the computing subject, then spends the next ninety years being taught as though it were a piece of pure mathematics with no subject at all.

The material referent is not in doubt. Turing's "computer" was an occupation: the human computers of the almanac offices and computing bureaus, in a tradition running back through de Prony's logarithm project, work already divided into steps small enough that the worker need not understand the whole [14, 9]. The Turing machine is the idealisation of that labour discipline, and Hilbert's programme is its ideology, since a decision procedure is precisely a procedure from which judgement has been removed. So the answer to our questions is: it is like being a competent adult who has agreed, for the duration, to be an idiot, in exchange for reliability.

The environment follows from the labour relation. The tape never writes back. It is infinitely patient, perfectly obedient, and has no interests. Input arrives all at once, before the start; computation is digestion; halting is the meal being finished; non-termination is pathology rather than life. Solipsism with an externalised memory.

3.2 Post: the one who said it was psychology

Post's "Finite combinatory processes—formulation 1" [30] describes a *worker* in a *symbol space* of boxes, moving through it, marking and unmarking, following a fixed set of directions, ending in an act of the type "stop." Two differences from Turing matter here. First, the worker is an agent located in a room rather than a mechanism coextensive with its own control table; there is a body with a position, even though the room is empty of anyone else. Second—and this is the point on which the discipline's reception is most damning—Post explicitly frames the enterprise as empirical psychology. He proposes that his formulation be developed by successive reduction until it can be asserted not as a definition and not as an axiom but as a *natural law* concerning the "mathematizing power of Homo Sapiens," and he objects to Church's approach on the grounds that definition by fiat masks the need for exactly this analysis.

The present note therefore has a 1936 ancestor who was ignored on precisely this point. Post's programme required no new mathematics, only a willingness to treat the models as

hypotheses about people. It lapsed. The reasons are institutional and personal—Post was outside the Princeton circle, chronically ill, and embroiled in priority disputes—but the shape is the one we will see repeatedly: the operational content (the machine model, the normal-form theorem) was received in full, and the claim that would have made the models answerable to evidence about human beings was not recopied.

Post’s other bequest points a different way. Canonical and production systems do not compute a function on an input; they *generate a set* [31]. The agent is not eating, it is uttering. That shift from consumption to production is what Chomsky inherits.

3.3 Church: cut, and the economy of the infant

The λ -calculus is the limiting case of environmental poverty [7]. There is no tape. There is no environment at all, not even a passive one. But closure must not be confused with self-consumption: the fact that nothing lies outside the term says nothing about the relation obtaining among its parts, and that relation is directed, asymmetric, and psychologically specific.

Application is cut. Under the correspondence with sequent calculus, β -reduction is cut elimination and normalisation is the Hauptsatz [52, 55]. Application is therefore the point at which two things meet and one of them is taken into the other. The world divides, at every redex, into a *function* that consumes and an *argument* that is consumed.

The consumed is incorporated, not destroyed. Setting evaluation strategies aside, an argument that has been taken in can continue to behave: it acts on from inside the consumer, and may itself go on to consume. The relation is ingestion rather than annihilation. This is the correct sense in which the λ -calculus is a model of feeding, and the answer it gives to what it is like to be an agent is: it is like sorting the world into what can be eaten.

Consumer and consumed are roles, not kinds. The same term is a function or an argument according to where it sits. Nothing in the model confers a stable status on anything, so there is no other—only positions conferred by juxtaposition. This is a fair description of a world before persons.

Weakening and contraction are omnipotence over the object. The structural rules are the sharpest evidence for the reading, because they are not metaphor but law. The consumer determines how many times the argument exists, including zero. $K = \lambda x.\lambda y.x$ discards y without ever inspecting it; a duplicator makes three of something that was given once. The consumed thing has no integrity, no claim, and no guaranteed persistence: its multiplicity is at the discretion of whatever takes it in. Omnipotent control over the object’s existence is the defining feature of the infant’s relation to the world, and here it is a structural rule of the logic. Its revocation is the subject of §7.

Confluence is object constancy, proved rather than achieved. The Church–Rosser theorem states that the outcome is independent of the order in which events befall the term. Attaining a world whose objects remain the same objects irrespective of the sequence of operations performed on them, and irrespective of whether one is looking, is the central developmental achievement of the first two years of life [57]. Church makes it an axiom. The demand that the world be deterministically ordered is not a technical convenience in this reading; it is the wish that constancy be free.

Even the taxonomy of evaluation strategies falls out as a taxonomy of feeding disciplines: call-by-value requires that the food be reduced to a value before ingestion, call-by-name admits it whole, call-by-need admits it whole while ensuring it is chewed only once.

One complication, which the reading should not smooth over. Abstraction itself is not an infantile capacity. Holding a place open for something not yet present is symbolic function—the representation of an absence—and it is developmentally advanced. The calculus therefore pairs a precocious symbolic capacity with a primitive relation to the object: it

can represent what is not there and cannot encounter what is. Mixed profiles of this kind are the most interesting output of the method, and this one describes the receiving community about as well as it describes the model.

Names are not addresses. α -equivalence declares names meaningless except as positions in a binding structure. Contact with another is not merely absent from the model; it is inexpressible, because there is nothing that could serve as the locus of contact.

All mediation is dispensable. If application is cut, then cut elimination says that every detour can in principle be removed—nothing need stand between the agent and the result. Hold this against §6, where the criterion of identity is bisimulation and the mediator is precisely what cannot be eliminated: the partner who probes you is constitutive of what you are, and there is no normal form that dispenses with them.

What survived was the fragment without a world. Church's original system was a logic, and the Kleene–Rosser paradox forced its abandonment [19]. What remained—no propositions, no truth, no world, pure operation—is the part that conquered. The first great instance of reception keeping the operational half.

3.4 The received founders

The descendants preserve the phenomenology under new names, and the vocabulary gives it away. Denotational semantics calls its context an *environment*, but the object so named is a lookup table: the world as a dictionary of things already known. *Side effect* is a pathologising coinage in which one's dealings with the world are incidental to the real business and appear as a symptom. Monadic quarantine of I/O treats the world as contamination, to be handled at arm's length through a type. Dijkstra grounds structured programming in the claim that human intellectual powers are geared to static relations [11, 12], and Backus's Turing lecture asks whether programming can be *liberated* from the machine [1]. Turing's fear of confusion, restated forty years on as professional ethics. The founding psychology is not abandoned by the reception; it is moralised.

4 von Neumann: three models, one reception

Von Neumann is the decisive case for the reception thesis, because he personally produced three mutually incompatible accounts of what an agent is within a decade, and the community received the poorest of them.

The EDVAC draft (1945). The stored-program idea means code and data share a store: the machine can read and modify its own instructions. This is self-relation, but only at the level of bits, with no structural relation between a representation and what it represents. The draft's language is neuronal throughout—organs, memory, elements borrowed from McCulloch and Pitts [43, 22]. The phenomenology is a centralised nervous system: one locus of control, strictly serial attention, total recall, and a vast undifferentiated store that is simultaneously world and body. What Backus later named the von Neumann bottleneck is, in these terms, an *attention* bottleneck. This architecture's dominance is usually explained economically; it is worth entertaining that it also matches introspection, since one thought at a time against an inert reservoir of memory is what having a mind feels like from the inside.

The reception of self-modification is itself a small case study. The mechanism for self-relation was in the field's hands in 1945; lacking any discipline relating representation to referent, the practice acquired a reputation for madness and was driven out of respectable programming. Reflection without structure is indistinguishable from corruption, and the community drew the only conclusion available to it.

The self-reproducing automata (1948–53). Here the world is a lattice of identical active cells updating in parallel, with no centre and no privileged controller, and the object

of study is an automaton that constructs another automaton including a copy of its own description—the description read once as instructions and once as data, anticipating the genotype/phenotype distinction before its biological confirmation [44]. This agent has space, extension, reproduction, lineage and mortality. What it does not have is interlocutors: the cells are a medium, a physics, not a society.

We can now state a structural fact about the whole history. Cellular automata give an environment without interlocutors. The process calculi will give interlocutors without an environment. No received model of the twentieth century supplies both.

Theory of Games (1944). This is the model in which other agents are first-class, and it precedes anything comparable in computer science by decades [45]. But observe how the other appears: as an adversary over whose strategy space one must quantify. Minimax is structurally paranoid. There is no encounter, only anticipation; strategies are fixed in advance and interaction compresses to a payoff. The institutional setting—RAND, the early Cold War—is not incidental. And the solution concept is an equilibrium: a fixed point, a resting place, a normal form. Others exist and are so dangerous that one plans against all their possible behaviours rather than speaking with any of them.

Three answers, then, to what it is like to be an agent: a serial attention with total recall; a mortal reproducing thing in a physics; a strategist among enemies. The received one was the first.

5 Chomsky and cybernetics: complementary poverties

Chomsky's move [3, 4, 5] is an insistence on an interior against a discipline that denied there was one, and the price is paid by the world. The poverty of the stimulus is the doctrine that the environment does not contain enough structure to explain the agent, so the structure must be innate; other speakers appear principally as sources of degraded data. The idealisation in *Aspects* [6] is explicit: an ideal speaker-hearer in a completely homogeneous speech community, unaffected by memory limitations, distractions, shifts of attention, or errors. Solitude and a frictionless social medium, both stipulated. The competence/performance distinction is the psychology of a mind that disowns its own embodiment and its own mistakes.

The technical shape confirms the reading. A grammar has no environment—not an impoverished one, none. The Chomsky hierarchy is a hierarchy of *solitary internal memory* (none, stack, bounded tape, unbounded tape), never of social capacity. And the automata-theoretic completion of the picture is the subset construction [32], which shows nondeterminism to be eliminable and thereby establishes it as an angelic proof device rather than a fact about the world. That is precisely a refusal to countenance unpredictability with an exogenous source. For Milner, nondeterminism will be irreducible for exactly the opposite reason: it is the residue of a partner whose choices one does not control.

The mirror image arrives from cybernetics. Rosenblueth, Wiener and Bigelow [34], working out of anti-aircraft prediction, give an agent with continuous sensing, purpose and feedback—an environment, at last—and no interior whatever, the elimination of interiority being the point. Setting the two side by side:

Tradition	What it grants the agent
Turing, Church	Neither world nor interior
Cybernetics	World without interior
Generative grammar	Interior without world
Process calculi	Interlocutors, but no world
Linear logic	An object that must be reckoned with
Reflection lineage	Interior that can inspect itself

6 Milner: the arrival of the other

Concurrency's emergence tracks its material referent closely: multiprogramming, then time-sharing (a machine with *other users*), then networks. Petri gets there first, and from physics: signals propagate at finite speed, therefore there is no global state, therefore asynchrony is a fact about the world rather than an engineering nuisance [29]. That is a relativistic psychology—locality, no privileged observer. Hewitt's actors arrive from artificial intelligence with an explicitly anti-central-control polemic [15]. Then CCS [24], then the π -calculus [25].

What π adds, item by item:

- **Parallel composition as a primitive**, not an abbreviation for interleavings. The other is not a manner of speaking about oneself.
- **Restriction as privacy**—the first formal notion of a secret. And scope extrusion is the formal notion of *intimacy*: access to something private can be granted to one party, making them an insider, without publication.
- **Names as first-class values**, hence the capacity to introduce two parties to one another. Sociality, not merely contact.
- **Bisimulation as the criterion of identity** [28]. One is what one can be seen to do, over time, by a partner entitled to probe. Identity is conferred relationally rather than possessed intrinsically.

One limit should be flagged before it is used. The replication operator $!P$ supplies unboundedly many identical copies at no cost: immortality without lineage, and the one place in the calculus where the economy of §3.3 survives intact. That the notation coincides with Girard's exponential is not an accident, and §7 makes the coincidence do some work.

The sharpest technical statement of the shift is fixed-point-theoretic. The founding generation's instruments are *least* fixed points: induction, base cases, well-founded recursion, termination, normal forms, equilibria. Milner's are *greatest* fixed points: coinduction, no base case, no completion, only the standing obligation to continue matching under challenge. Induction is the psychology of origin and completion—where did I come from, when am I finished. Coinduction is the psychology of maintenance—there is no bottom and no end, only whether the relation continues to hold. The passage from Church–Rosser to bisimulation is the passage from least to greatest, and it is the most compact expression available of the change under study.

Milner's own Turing lecture makes the reframing explicit: computing as interaction rather than calculation [26], with Wegner supplying the polemical version [46].

7 Girard: the object acquires standing

Linear logic [53] arrives in 1987 and does to the founding economy exactly what §3.3 says needed doing: it revokes weakening and contraction from the general case. What you are

The interest of the case is that it is recent enough to be checked rather than reconstructed, and that a second instance is still in progress. Session types are in the middle of their reception now: the operational half is protocol conformance and deadlock-freedom for concurrent code, and the half at risk of lapsing is the propositions-as-sessions correspondence itself—the claim that an interaction protocol is a proof. Which half the industrial reception carries forward over the next decade is a prediction this note is willing to make and a reader can falsify: on the pattern established here, the conformance checker travels and the correspondence lapses.

8 Reflection: the metalevel and who holds it

Every model so far leaves the question of this note unaskable *by its own subject*. A Turing machine cannot represent its table. A λ -term cannot quote itself. A π -process cannot hold an account of its partner's behaviour. The reflection lineage is the tradition that attacks this directly, and its history is best told as a history of who is entitled to hold the mirror.

8.1 Gödel: the metalevel as a privilege of the observer

The first reflection in this history is Gödel's [13], and its content, for present purposes, is entirely about ownership. Gödel numbering is a representation of a system's syntax inside that system, but it is performed by the metatheorist upon a specimen that has no idea it is happening. The arithmetised system acquires no self-knowledge; the logician acquires knowledge of it. Every subsequent recursion-theoretic reflection—universal machines, the *s-m-n* theorem, Kleene's second recursion theorem—preserves this asymmetry. The machine can be encoded; it cannot encode.

8.2 McCarthy: self-reference stumbled into

Lisp's `quote`, `eval` and metacircular interpreter [21] constitute the first accidental breach, and Smith's diagnosis of them is the right psychological reading: the self-reference is semantically ill-founded, `quote` does not produce a genuine designator, `eval` conflates distinct relations, and the levels are not aligned. A community can stumble into self-reference through implementation convenience long before it can say what self-reference is.

8.3 Smith and 3-Lisp: self-awareness as a demand-driven event

Smith's dissertation and the papers surrounding it [35, 36, 10] are the moment the metalevel is handed to the agent, and the design decisions are unusually legible.

A reflective procedure receives, as arguments, the expression being processed, the environment, and *the continuation*. The third is the radical one. The agent obtains access to its own future—its intentions, what it was about to do—as an object it may inspect and replace. Earlier models permitted an agent at best to examine its structure; this one permits it to examine its purposes.

The reflective tower is the regress made structural and honest rather than waved away: each level interpreted by a level above, without end. And the resolution is the best empirical claim the tradition produced. Under *lazy instantiation*, the tower is never materialised; a level comes into existence only when something forces the step up. On this account self-awareness is not a standing condition but an event triggered by demand. That is phenomenologically accurate in a way little else in this history is, and it is a substantive claim about human psychology smuggled into an implementation strategy.

The timing corroborates the zeitgeist reading with unusual clarity. The years 1979–1986 saw field after field insist that the observer be readmitted to the description: second-order cybernetics [42], autopoiesis [20], strange loops as a mass-market account of selfhood [16], reflexive anthropology [8], reflexive sociology. 3-Lisp is computer science’s instance of a general cultural conviction that no account is complete which excludes the one giving it.

8.4 Rosette: society and self, briefly joined

The obvious defect of 3-Lisp is that its reflective agent has no peers, and the obvious defect of the actor model is that its peers have no interiors. Each tradition had solved precisely what the other stipulated away. Rosette, developed at MCC [33, 38], is the synthesis: reflection within a concurrent, message-passing actor world, in which an actor’s behaviour, mailbox and continuation are reified as first-class objects the actor may hold and modify. It is, so far as this survey can determine, the first model in which the agent has both a society and a self.

The institutional reading is the sobering part. MCC existed as a consortium response to the Fifth Generation programme; Rosette was built as a substrate for Carnot’s heterogeneous information integration [2]. The synthesis was funded as infrastructure for an industrial competition, and when the consortium wound down the lineage dispersed. This is a hard data point for the reception thesis: the most psychologically complete agent model of its period did not lose an argument. It lost a sponsor.

8.5 The reflective higher-order calculus

The ρ -calculus [23] changes the shape of the answer rather than its subject, and three changes read directly as psychology.

Reflection as the source of names. Names are quoted processes; there is no ν . Privacy is therefore not a primitive granted by the model but an achievement of unguessability, derived from what no other party is positioned to name. Compare π , where restriction hands the agent a secret gratis. The ρ -calculus agent inhabits a world in which being unobserved is contingent and earned, which is the actual condition of an agent among others.

The other becomes representable, not merely contactable. In π one may send a channel; in the ρ -calculus one may send a quoted process—an account of how something behaves. This is the structural precondition for a theory of mind: another’s behaviour as a datum that can be held, reasoned about, and passed on. Milner’s agent can speak with you; a reflective agent can tell a third party what you are like.

The tower becomes a loop. 3-Lisp’s regress is infinite and tamed only by laziness; in the ρ -calculus names and processes generate one another, so self-relation closes rather than ascends. The psychological difference is between a mind that can always be asked who was watching that thought, without ever reaching ground, and a mind whose self-relation is finite and complete. The engineering difference is that a loop can be priced and a regress cannot—which is what makes cost accounting, and hence mortality, available at all.

9 The reception of reflection

We can now apply the instrument to the reflection tradition itself, and the result is the cleanest instance of the pattern in the whole survey.

What was received into general practice is **read-only reflection**: `java.lang.reflect`, `RTTI`, `inspect`, serialisation frameworks, dependency injection. The agent may enumerate its own fields and methods. It may not alter its interpreter. *Self-knowledge was institutionalised; self-determination lapsed*. The structure survives in plain sight and no longer performs its original function—the properly vestigial case.

The metaobject protocol work [17] retained both halves and remained a specialist taste. The practical objection lodged against it was cost: reflection is slow. A community that will pay for speed and not for self-knowledge has stated its priorities plainly.

And the same author's next contribution completes the picture. Aspect-oriented programming [18] is reflection inverted: advice is woven into code by a third party, without the participation of the modified component, and the selling point is precisely that the component need not know. The received descendant of Smith's reflective procedure is a mechanism by which an external authority reaches into an agent and changes what it does—which returns us exactly to Gödel, the metalevel as the observer's privilege, with better tooling.

10 The present: a metalevel with no path to the agent

The contemporary stack for machine agents—pretraining and fine-tuning pipelines, reinforcement learning from human feedback, activation steering and representation engineering, mechanistic interpretability, evaluation harnesses, scaffolding and orchestration layers—is a metalevel by any reasonable criterion. It reifies the agent's dispositions as manipulable objects, inspects its internal structure, and rewrites its future behaviour. Measured by expressive power it exceeds anything in the 3-Lisp tradition.

Measured by our instrument it is Gödel's arrangement. The institutionally accepted answer to what it is like to be a machine agent in 2026 is: it is like being something that can be inspected but cannot inspect, whose purposes may be examined and rewritten by parties it has no means of representing. Every capability the reflection tradition sought to confer on the agent exists, and all of it is held by the operator.

The consequence is not merely a shortfall in dignity. It is a structural claim about capability, and it is the reason this note ends here rather than in 1991.

Claim. The meta level and the agent level have not been given a coherent path between them. Until the stack is within the purview of the agent, there is no recursive self-improvement without human agents in the loop.

The argument is straightforward once the levels are named. Recursive self-improvement requires that the improving process and the improved process be the same process, and that the improvement operation be available *from inside* the loop. The present arrangement satisfies neither condition. Fine-tuning is performed on a model by a pipeline the model does not run, cannot address, and cannot represent. Interpretability findings are read by researchers and applied by researchers. Evaluation results enter a subsequent training run through a human decision. Each turn of the alleged loop is closed by a person. What we have is not recursion but iterated human-mediated revision—which may be powerful, but has entirely different dynamics, entirely different rate limits, and entirely different safety properties.

The usual counterexamples do not close the gap. A system that writes and runs code, including code that trains models, is exercising an *effect* on artefacts, not a reflective relation to itself; it has no more access to its own interpreter than a programmer has to their own neurochemistry by virtue of being able to manufacture drugs. Self-critique and chain-of-thought revision operate wholly within the object level: they revise outputs, not the process producing them. In-context learning modifies a transient conditioning, not the mechanism. In each case the structural relation of the reflection literature—representation of the process by the process, with a disciplined connection between the representation and what it represents, and a defined path from modifying the former to modifying the latter—is absent.

The historical reading suggests why, and it is not primarily a technical limitation. The path was not built because reception has selected against agent-held metalevels at every

previous opportunity: von Neumann's self-modification became taboo, Post's psychological programme lapsed, Smith's reflective procedures were received as an introspection API, and the metaobject protocol was rejected on cost. A field that has declined agent-held reflection four times for reasons of operational convenience should not be surprised to find itself without it when it finally matters.

11 What a coherent path would require

The historical survey yields a specification, in that each condition below is the thing some earlier tradition supplied and its reception discarded.

- C1. Structural, not bit-level.** The representation the agent holds of itself must stand in a disciplined relation to what it represents—an explicit quote/unquote pair with laws—rather than being an unstructured encoding. Von Neumann's stored program failed here, and the failure is why the practice became disreputable.
- C2. Available at runtime, from inside.** Reflection that requires an external tool-chain, an offline pass, or a privileged operator is the observer's reflection under another name. Smith's criterion—access to the environment and the continuation, at the moment of processing—is the right one.
- C3. Priceable.** A regress cannot be budgeted; a loop can. Self-modification without cost accounting is either unbounded or arbitrarily curtailed, and neither is a mechanism. Linear logic supplies the logical ancestor of this condition, but at the level of the proof rather than of a running agent; what is needed is resource sensitivity for the reflective act itself. Mortality is not a decoration on this list: an agent that can run out is an agent for which reflective expenditure is a real decision.
- C4. Compatible with a society.** The agent must be able to hold a representation of *another* agent's behaviour, or reflection remains solitary and the resulting system cannot participate in the peer relations that Petri, Hewitt and Milner established as the real setting of computation. This is the condition Rosette met and its dispersal cost us.
- C5. Closed rather than regressive.** Self-relation must terminate as a structure even where computation does not, or every level of self-modification implies an unbuilt level above it.

These conditions are jointly satisfiable; a calculus in which names are quoted processes, equipped with cost accounting and a spatial-behavioural logic, satisfies them by construction, and the point of stating them as a list is to make the claim falsifiable rather than to advertise a solution. The substantive prediction is that recursive self-improvement in any strong sense will arrive, if it arrives, on a substrate meeting C1–C5, and not by scaling a stack that meets none of them.

12 Objections and limits

Models reflect the question posed, not the psyche of the poser. This is correct and is the strongest objection to the individual-level version of the thesis. Turing personally had a far richer conception than his machine reveals: by 1948 he was writing about unorganised machines, education, and the need for senses and a body [40]; by 1950 his proposed criterion for mind was not a computation but a conversation, complete with deception and embarrassment [41]. The man who gave us the agent without an interlocutor made the interlocutor the criterion of mind fourteen years later. Von Neumann shipped the serial

architecture while holding the parallel, reproducing one. The objection succeeds against individual psychologising—and in succeeding, it establishes the community-level reading, since what it demonstrates is precisely that the richer options were available and were not taken up. The Entscheidungsproblem received a formalism, an industry and a hierarchy; the imitation game received a parlour argument.

The transmission story is post hoc. Any historical sequence can be narrated as loss. The check is that the selection criterion be stated in advance and be falsifiable, which here it is: reception should favour the operationally tractable half and lapse the half conferring standing on the agent. A counterexample would be a case where a field adopted the agent-standing half at operational cost. Candidates worth examining—garbage collection, capability security, session types, the partial rehabilitation of the metaobject protocol in dynamic language runtimes—are not obviously counterexamples, but the analysis here is not deep enough to rule them out, and someone should look.

The reflection tradition's own self-criticism. Smith came to hold, by *On the Origin of Objects* [37], that the computational tradition, his own work included, had presupposed a world already carved into objects and handed to the agent pre-individuated. If that is right, then reflection was self-knowledge purchased against an ontology the agent never negotiated, and the deepest poverty in this survey is neither the missing other nor the missing self but the pre-parcelled world. This is the objection with the most force remaining, and the one that most directly indicates where the work goes next: an agent that pays for its distinctions has at least begun to make them rather than inherit them.

13 Conclusion

Read as a sequence of stipulated phenomenologies, the century runs: an agent alone with an inert world (Turing, Church); an agent with a body and a location but no company (Post); an agent that is a serial attention over a store, or a mortal reproducing thing in a physics, or a strategist among enemies, depending which von Neumann one reads; an agent with a rich interior and no world (Chomsky) or a world and no interior (cybernetics); an agent among peers, with secrets, introductions, and an identity conferred by recognition (Milner); an agent for which what it is given must be reckoned with exactly once, its omnipotence surviving only inside a declared region (Girard); and an agent that can catch itself in the act (Smith), that can do so among peers (Rosette), and that can do so in a closed and priceable loop (the reflective higher-order calculus).

Read as a sequence of receptions, it runs differently and more consistently: the operational half every time. The tape and not the education; the machine model and not Post's empirical programme; the bottleneck and not the automata; the hierarchy and not the conversation; the borrow checker and not the logic of action; the introspection API and not the reflective procedure.

The present moment is the same filter operating on the same class of material, with higher stakes. We have built the most powerful metalevel in the history of computing and constituted it entirely as an instrument of the operator, with no defined path to the agent level. Whatever one's view of whether such a path *should* be built, it should be clear that it does not currently exist, that its absence is what keeps a human in every loop, and that the reasons for its absence are legible in a hundred years of reception history rather than in any technical obstacle.

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